

A World of Regions: The Global Divides

The North and the South

- **The North–South Divide definition:** "refers to the long-standing economic, social, and political gap between the world's more developed and industrialized countries, commonly identified as the Global North, and the less developed countries of the Global South."
- **Scope:** It captures broad patterns of inequality in income, technological capacity, infrastructure, governance, and overall development outcomes.
- **Global North characteristics:** Typically possess diversified economies, strong institutions, and higher living standards.
- **Global South characteristics:** Face challenges such as limited industrial capacity, dependence on primary exports, and structural vulnerabilities.
- **Root causes:** This divide is rooted in historical processes like colonialism, imperial expansion, and unequal trade systems that shaped the distribution of wealth, resources, and political power.

Historical Context of the Divide

- **Colonial Legacy:** Traced back to the colonial era when European powers colonized vast territories in Africa, Asia, and Latin America, exploiting resources and labor while imposing economic structures that favored colonizers.
- **Consequences of colonialism:**
 1. **Colonial mentality:** "The perception that one's identity is inferior compared to foreign culture and ethnicity."
 2. **Racism:** "The behaviors or attitudes that reflect and foster the belief that race is a fundamental determinant of human traits, where differences make one (1) superior."
 3. **Discrimination:** "The unjust (or prejudicial) treatment of different categories of people, particularly with their ethnicity, age, sex, or disability."
- **Unequal Trade Relationships:** Colonizers imposed trade patterns benefiting their economies, dating back to the Age of Exploration (Portugal and Spain dividing the world) and intensifying during the Industrial Revolution with slavery and resource exploitation.

Economic Disparities

- **Per Capita Income:** High in the Global North; Low in the Global South.
- **Access to Technological Advancement:** Easy in the Global North; Difficult in the Global South.
- **Employment Sectors:** Technology-based, finance-focused, and manufacturing in the Global North; Agriculture-focused, export-heavy, and labor-intensive in the Global South.

Social and Political Implications

- **Access to Education, Healthcare, and Basic Services:** High in the Global North; Low in the Global South.
- **Global Governance:** Can influence in the Global North; Can barely contribute in the Global South.

Poverty and Wealth Inequity

- **Positive Impacts of Globalization:** Can create new economic opportunities via expanded markets, foreign investments, and technological advancements; generates jobs; increases incomes.
- **Negative Impacts of Globalization:** Can exacerbate poverty by widening income inequalities; may face challenges in competing with more advanced economies; may lead to job losses in traditional sectors; increases vulnerability for marginalized populations.

Impact on Latin America

- **Historical forces:** Current challenges are rooted in Cold War interventions, authoritarian legacies, and persistent institutional weaknesses.
- **Income Inequality:** A small elite holds a disproportionate share of wealth compared to the majority of the population.
- **The Global Market:** Faces challenges in accessing global markets on equal terms due to trade barriers, tariffs, and unequal trade agreements.
- **Commodities:** Heavy reliance on exports of primary commodities (such as oil, minerals, and agricultural products) leads to economic instability and vulnerability.
- **Social and Human Development:** Poverty and social exclusion persist, with portions of the population lacking access to basic services, driving migration to more developed regions.
- **Political Influence and Governance:** Less influence in global decision-making forums; economic disparities contribute to political instability, corruption, social unrest, and political polarization.
- **Technological Access and Digital Divide:** Disparities in internet access and connectivity between urban and rural areas, as well as limited research and development investment.
- **Environmental and Climate Challenges:** Disproportionately affected by global environmental policies and climate change, facing deforestation, biodiversity loss, natural disasters, and conflicts over resource extraction.

Impact on the Philippines

- **Global South Position:** Positioned within the strategic interests of global powers due to its location in the Asia-Pacific, leading to colonization, Cold War-era alignments, and contemporary geopolitical competition.
- **Economic Growth:** Integration into global markets stimulated growth in sectors like BPO, manufacturing, and tourism, though the economy remains vulnerable to geopolitical tensions, global recessions, and international labor demand.

- **Income Inequality:** Wealth remains concentrated in urban centers and certain sectors, leaving rural areas and marginalized communities behind due to historical land concentration, weak labor protections, and dependence on low-value exports.
- **Geopolitical Pressures and Regional Security:** Situated in a contested region where major powers compete for influence, with issues like the South China Sea dispute, foreign military presence, and security alliances shaping domestic policy.

UN's Role in Mitigating Poverty and Wealth Inequity through SDGs

- **SDG 1: No Poverty:** The UN aims to eradicate extreme poverty globally, ensuring that all people have access to basic resources, services, and economic opportunities.
- **SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities:** Addressing inequalities within and among countries by advocating for policies that empower marginalized groups, promote social protection systems, and ensure equal access to resources and opportunities.

A World of Regions: Asian Regionalism

Asian Regionalism

- **Asian regionalism definition:** "refers to the process of Asian countries coming together to foster cooperation, integration, and collective decision-making within the region."
- **Goals:** This regional cooperation aims to enhance economic growth, political stability, and cultural exchange among Asian nations.
- **Regional Organizations:**
 - **Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC)** (Founded: 1989): "Promote sustainable economic growth and prosperity in the Asia-Pacific region." Founding members include Australia, Brunei, Canada, Indonesia, Japan, South Korea, Malaysia, New Zealand, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, and the United States.
 - **Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)** (Founded: 1967): Focuses on economic integration, political cooperation, social progress, and cultural development. Members include Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, and Vietnam.
 - **Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC)** (Founded: 1997): "To ensure dynamic and mutual cooperation, especially in the areas that are of common interest to the member countries" and "To create an environment for ensuring expeditious economic growth in the South Asian and Southeast Asian countries." Members include Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Thailand.
 - **South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)** (Founded: 1985): Promotes "regional cooperation in economic, social, cultural, technical, and scientific fields" and attempts to "address common challenges in the region and foster regional stability." Members include Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka.
 - **South Asia Subregional Economic Cooperation (SASEC)** (Founded: 2001): Focuses on "enhancing cross-border connectivity between the member nations, promoting trade and economic growth." Members include Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, and Sri Lanka.

Regional Dynamics and Divisions in Asia

- **Political Divisions and Regional Tensions:** Asia is marked by unresolved territorial disputes and historical grievances (such as the South China Sea claims, the Kashmir dispute, and tensions in the Korean Peninsula) that complicate regional cooperation and hinder consensus-building.
- **Security Challenges and Strategic Rivalries:** Major powers pursue competing security strategies, contributing to military modernization and regional instability,

driven by rivalries among China, India, and Japan, as well as North Korea's nuclear capabilities.

- **Economic Inequalities and Development Gaps:** The region exhibits significant disparities in wealth, industrial capacity, and technological advancement, contrasting highly developed economies (like Japan, South Korea, and Singapore) with lower-income nations in South and Southeast Asia.
- **Social and Cultural Fragmentation:** Linguistic, ethnic, and religious diversity creates internal divisions, social tensions, and identity-based conflicts, further shaped by migration flows driven by economic need and political crises.
- **Institutional Limitations:** Unlike regions with strong supranational institutions, Asian regional organizations operate through consensus and non-interference, limiting their ability to enforce regional norms or address conflicts decisively amidst competing visions for regional leadership like China's Belt and Road Initiative and Indo-Pacific strategies.

Sexual Orientation and Gender Identity Expression (SOGIE)

- **Awareness and Visibility:** Global ideas and advocacy from Western countries influence discussions and perceptions, while platforms like ASEAN and SAARC facilitate exchanges among member states.
- **Legal and Policy Frameworks:** Global entities exert pressure to adhere to international human rights norms, though varied legal protections are adopted across Asian countries based on cultural and political contexts.
- **Social and Cultural Attitudes:** Globalization exposes Asia to diverse perspectives that challenge traditional norms, though SOGIE expression remains influenced by local cultural and religious beliefs.
- **Challenges and Resistance:** Resistance to perceived foreign influences creates conservative backlash, and continued legal and social stigma affects advocacy and societal attitudes.
- **Access to Services and Support:** Globalization enhances access to healthcare, support networks, and digital connectivity via increased internet access, bridging gaps in regions with limited local resources.

Indigenous Peoples in the Philippine Context

- **Economic Integration:** Increased global trade and investment may lead to the exploitation of natural resources in Indigenous Peoples' (IP) lands for commercial gain, while regional economic frameworks offer market participation alongside risks of marginalization and land loss.
- **Cultural Identity and Preservation:** Exposure to global cultures enriches diversity but threatens traditional knowledge, while regional and global recognition promotes cultural pride and heritage conservation.
- **Legal and Land Rights:** Global human rights norms influence Philippine policies on land rights and self-determination, and regional networks enhance advocacy and legal protections.
- **Education and Social Development:** Globalization may improve access to education and social services, though cultural biases, language barriers, and limited infrastructure can hinder effective learning and quality of life.

- **Environmental Impact:** Global market demand for natural resources can cause environmental degradation and loss of traditional lands, while cross-border collaboration on conservation initiatives can benefit indigenous territories.